

Despite the mass of incontrovertible proof to the contrary, there are still ultra patriots and professional chauvinists who believe that the Colonial tradition entailed a repudiation of classical—and particularly European or foreign—art and culture. From this fallacious concept it is only a short step to the theory that *all* cultural activities are un-American and unsuited for red-blooded Americans.

As if these influences—the Puritan and what might be termed the pseudo-Colonial traditions—were not enough, the average American man's attitude toward culture has been further warped by the mythical mystique of the American frontier heritage. The rough-and-ready, generally unlettered and often uncouth, frontiersman long ago became the figure after which generations of American men would subconsciously pattern themselves. Believing that they are emulating praiseworthy qualities of their pioneer forebears, many U.S. males sneer at any art above the

September Morn level and jeer at any music that cannot be played on a honky-tonk piano or twanged and scraped out by a self-taught banjo player and an amateur fiddler.

The figure of the two-fisted, fast-drawing and culture-hating frontiersman may be picturesque, but it is a misleading one.

There were many cultured men—and men who thirsted for culture—as well as barroom brawlers and gunslingers on the American frontier.

It is, perhaps, significant to note the examples provided by two rough, tough cities that played important roles in

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America's Westward expansion—San Francisco and Denver.

San Francisco's Barbary Coast and Denver's Holladay Street were probably the wickedest and wildest enclaves in all the wild, wild West. Even so, there were few Eastern metropolises that gave such quick and unstinting support to cultural projects as did San Francisco and Denver, even in their raucous infancy.